

Session 22: Why Does Jonah Flee to Tarshish?

Key Takeaways

- Concentric symmetry is when the center of a movement acts as a moment of emphasis or highlight.
- Jonah was the last prophet to prophecy the restoration of Israel's borders to an Eden-like proportion, but that was all reversed by Babylon in the next generation.
- All mentions of "the ships of Tarshish" in the Hebrew Bible are negative. Tarshish is the place people go to build their false Edens.

Jonah's Commission: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 1:1-3

¹ The word of the Lord came to Jonah the son of Amittai saying,

² " **Arise** ,
go to Nineveh the great city
and call out against it,
for their wickedness has come up before me."

a ³ And Jonah **arose** to flee **to Tarshish from before the face of Yahweh** .

b **And he went down** to Joppa,

c and he found a ship

d which was **going** to **Tarshish**

c' and he paid the fare

b' **and he went down** into it

a' to **go** with them **to Tarshish from before the face of Yahweh** .

Jonah 1:1-3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019)

Jonah's Name (1:1)

"Jonah, son of Amittai" = "dove, son of faithfulness"

Faithfulness = אֱמֶתִי / yonah = dove / יוֹנָה

Jonah, Prophet of God's Mercy and Israel's Restoration

Jonah first appears in 2 Kings 14:25-26, where he prophesied that the borders of Israel would be restored to their original borders from the days of Solomon, which happened during the reign of Jeroboam II. However, the narrator also makes clear that Jeroboam II “did evil in the eyes of Yahweh” in perpetuating the sins of Jeroboam I (2 Kgs. 14:24), so there is more than meets the eye here.

Jonah’s Prophecy and God’s Mercy on Sinful Israel

Narrative	2 Kings 13: Reign of Jehoahaz	2 Kings 14: Reign of Jeroboam II
Apostate King of Northern Israel	13:2: [Jehoahaz] did evil in the eyes of Yahweh and he followed the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, which he caused Israel to sin.	14:24: [Jeroboam II] did evil in the eyes of Yahweh, he did not turn away from the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, which he caused Israel to sin.
Yahweh’s Response	Judgment and Oppression 13:3: And the anger of Yahweh was hot against Israel and he gave them into the hand of Hazael king of Aram and into the hand of Ben-Hadad son of Hazael ... 13:22: Now Hazael king of Aram had oppressed Israel all the days of Jehoahaz.	Blessing and Victory?! 14:25: He restored the border of Israel from the entrance of Hamath as far as the Sea of the Arabah, according to the word of the Lord, the God of Israel, which he spoke through his servant Jonah the son of Amittai, the prophet, who was of Gath-hepher.
Repentance of the King	13:4a: Then Jehoahaz appeased the face of Yahweh and Yahweh listened to him.	No repentance!
Divine Mercy	13:4b: Because [Yahweh] saw the oppression of Israel, which the king of Aram oppressed them. 13:23a: But Yahweh was gracious to them and had compassion on them and turned toward them because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob , and he would not destroy them ...	14:26-27a: For the Lord saw the affliction of Israel, which was very bitter; for there was neither bond nor free, nor was there any helper for Israel. The Lord did not say that he would blot out the name of Israel from under heaven ...

Jonah’s Prophecy and God’s Mercy on Sinful Israel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Narrative	2 Kings 13: Reign of Jehoahaz	2 Kings 14: Reign of Jeroboam II
Provision of a Deliverer	13:5: And Yahweh provided for Israel a deliverer and they went out from under the hand of Aram and the sons of Israel sat in their tents as in former times.	14:27b: But he delivered them by the hand of Jeroboam the son of Joash.
Jonah's Prophecy and God's Mercy on Sinful Israel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

In the sequence of 2 Kings 13-14, we have two contrasting generations of Israelite kings. Jehoahaz is wicked, but he appeals to Yahweh's mercy (in the language of Exodus 34:6), so Yahweh delivers Israel in his generation. Contrast this with Jeroboam II, who is also wicked but does not repent, yet Yahweh blesses him with victory and divine mercy with the prophetic support of Jonah ben Amittai.

The author of Jonah assumes a knowledge of this section of 2 Kings and builds his portrait of Jonah in light of this story of undeserved divine mercy to sinful kingdoms.

“If God just goes around forgiving everybody all the time, what’s the point of doing anything? If disobedience goes cavalierly unpunished, then the idea of obedience ceases to have meaning, and this is why Jonah ends up in the grip of a deathwish in Jonah ch. 4 ... [I]n Jonah’s perception, the deity has sovereign power over everything but himself, a situation that allows sin to flourish unchecked and sinners (like Jeroboam or the Ninevites) to reap rewards.”

Muldoon, Catherine (2016). “In Defense of Divine Justice: An Intertextual Approach to the Book of Jonah.” *Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*, vol. 16. 120-121.

Jonah’s Prophecy and the Garden of Eden

The restoration of the borders in 2 Kings 14:24-26 links back to the borders of Israel realized only in the time of Solomon, which themselves go back to the land borders promised to Abraham in Genesis 15, and even further back to the borders of Eden in Genesis 2.

Genesis 2:10-14 NASB

¹⁰ Now a river flowed out of Eden to water the garden; and from there it divided and became four rivers. ¹¹ The name of the first is Pishon; it flows around the whole land of Havilah, where there is gold. ¹² The gold of that land is good; the bdellium and the onyx stone are there. ¹³ The name of the second river is Gihon; it flows around the whole land of Cush. ¹⁴ The name of the third river is Tigris; it flows east of Assyria. And the fourth river is the Euphrates.

1 Kings 4:21 NASB

Now Solomon ruled over all the kingdoms **from the river to the land of the Philistines and to the border of Egypt**; they brought tribute and served Solomon all the days of his life.

Genesis 15:18 NASB

On that day the LORD made a covenant with Abram, saying,
"To your descendants I have given this land,
from the river of Egypt as far as the great river, the river Euphrates:"

1 Kings 8:65 NIV

So Solomon observed the festival at that time, and all Israel with him—a vast assembly, people **from Lebo Hamath to the Wadi of Egypt**.

Joshua 1:4 NIV

Your territory will extend **from the desert to Lebanon, and from the great river, the Euphrates**—all the Hittite country—to the Mediterranean Sea in the west.

2 Kings 14:25 NIV

[Jeroboam ben Joash] was the one who restored the boundaries of Israel **from Lebo Hamath to the Dead Sea**, in accordance with the word of the LORD, the God of Israel, spoken through his servant Jonah son of Amittai, the prophet from Gath Hepher.

These links are all connected to the promise to Abraham, that his seed would inherit a land whose borders resemble the land encompassed by the rivers of Eden in Genesis 2. These borders are what Joshua is told to possess and what Solomon reigns over for a short period until losing the north to Aram ([1 Kgs. 11:23-25](#)). Ironically, it is Jeroboam II who restores the Eden-like borders of Israel, as prophesied by Jonah son of Amittai.

Jonah's Prophecy and Jeroboam's Victory Reversed

It's crucially important to note that Jeroboam's border restoration and Jonah's prophecy are intentionally reversed by an oracle from the prophet Amos. So whatever positive associations we had in [2 Kings 14](#) must be tempered by the eventual reversal of Jonah's prophecy brought on by Israel's apostasy.

2 Kings 14:24-25 NASB

²⁴ Jeroboam did evil in the sight of the LORD; he did not depart from all the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat, which he made Israel sin. ²⁵ He restored the border of Israel from the entrance of Hamath as far as the Sea of the Arabah, according to the word of the LORD, the God of Israel, which he spoke through his servant Jonah the son of Amittai, the prophet, who was of Gath-hepher.

Amos 6:13-14 NASB

¹³ You who rejoice in Lodebar,
and say, "Have we not by our own strength taken Karnaim for ourselves?"
¹⁴ "For behold, I am going to raise up a nation against you,
O house of Israel," declares the LORD God of hosts,
"And they will afflict you from the entrance of Hamath
to the brook of the Arabah."

The nation that God will use to reverse Jonah's prophecy and fulfill Amos' warning is none other than Assyria, who will eventually destroy the entire northern kingdom of Israel.

2 Kings 15:27-29 NASB

²⁷ In the fifty-second year of Azariah king of Judah, Pekah son of Remaliah became king over Israel in Samaria, and reigned twenty years. ²⁸ He did evil in the sight of the LORD; he did not depart from the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, which he made Israel sin.

²⁹ In the days of Pekah king of Israel, Tiglath-pileser king of Assyria came and captured Ijon and Abel-beth-maacah and Janoah and Kedesh and Hazor and Gilead and Galilee, all the land of Naphtali; and he carried them captive to Assyria.

2 Kings 16:9 NASB

[Then] ... the king of Assyria went up against Damascus and captured it, and carried the people of it away into exile to Kir, and put Rezin to death.

Nineveh, the Great City

The phrase "Nineveh, the great city" appears four times in Jonah ([Jon. 1:2](#); [3:2](#), [3](#); [4:11](#)) and only elsewhere in Genesis 10 in a crucially important story about the founding of Babylon and Nineveh.

Genesis 10:10-12 NASB*

¹⁰ The beginning of [Nimrod's] kingdom was Babylon and Erech and Akkad and Calneh, in the land of Shinar.

¹¹ From that land Asshur went out, and he built Nineveh and the wide-ness-of-city and Calah, ¹² and Resen between Nineveh and Calah; that is the great city.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Asshur's kingdom consists of four cities, just as Nimrod's Babylon. From this point on, these two empires will loom in the background until Assyria appears in [2 Kings 15](#) (right after Jonah) as a precursor to the Babylonian threat.

"The deliberate association of Assyria with Babylon (in Gen 10:11-12) is significant; otherwise, in the lists of names which follow, Assyria is associated with the sons of Shem (Gen 10:22). By means of this narrative insertion, then, the author has not only introduced a key city, Babylon, but has also taken Assyria out of its natural associations with Shem and given it a new identification with Babylon. Thus the author has opened the way for an association and identification of other cities with Babylon. These appear to be the initial stirrings of a larger-than life symbolic value for Babylon, one known in a fully developed sense in the book of Isaiah (chs. 13-14 where Assyria is identified with Babylon), and in Micah 5:6, where the prophet could speak of Assyria as the 'land of Nimrod.'"

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-Theological Commentary](#). Zondervan Academic. 132.

Rising Evil

The phrase “their evil has risen up before me” connects to an important biblical design pattern of the evil human city whose violence forms an outcry that rises up to God.

Genesis 4:10 NASB*

The blood of your brother is crying out to me (צעקים אלי) from the ground.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Cain and Abel and Cain’s city of violence

Genesis 6:13 NASB*

The end of all flesh has come before me (לפני בא).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The generation of the flood

Genesis 18:20-21 NASB*

²⁰ The outcry (זעקה) against Sodom and Gomorrah, it is great and their sin is extremely heavy. ²¹ I will go down now and I will see if its outcry (צעקה) which has come to me (אלי הבאה) they have done, totally.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Sodom and Gomorrah

Exodus 2:23 NASB*

And they cried out (זעק) and their outcry rose up to God (אל אלהים ... ותעל) from their slavery.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Israelites in Egypt

Jonah 1:2 NASB*

For their evil has risen up before me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ninevah

In each of these stories, God raises up a deliverer/intercessor who either:

1. Confronts the evil-doers and calls them to repent (Moses in Egypt), or
2. Pleads with God on behalf of the wicked (Noah’s sacrifice, Abraham’s intercession)

But this is not the case with Jonah.

Jonah’s Flight from God

Jonah 1:3 NASB*

And Jonah arose to flee ... from before the face of Yahweh (יהוה מלפני).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The phrase “from before the face of Yahweh” refers to the divine presence and appears 16 times in the Hebrew Bible. The first time is in the story of Cain’s exile east of Eden after his brother’s blood cries out from the ground. This interpretation is confirmed by the fact that the author returns to a series of clear analogies between Jonah and Cain in Jonah 4.

Genesis 4:16 NASB*

And he went out from before the face of Yahweh (מלפני יהוה).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Cain's exile from Eden

Jonah 1:3 NASB*

And Jonah arose to flee ... from before the face of Yahweh (יהוה מלפני).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah's flight from God

Cain in Genesis 4

Genesis 4:4b-5 Instructor’s Translation

^{4b} And Yahweh regarded Abel and his offering, ⁵ but Cain and his offering he did not regard, and there was heat-anger to Cain (ל ויחר-).

Genesis 4:6-7 Instructor’s Translation

⁶ “Why is there heat-anger to you (לך חרה)? ⁷ Isn’t it the case that if you do good (תיטיב) there is exaltation?”

Genesis 4:16 NASB*

And Cain went out (ויצא) from before the face of Yahweh and he sat (וישב) in the land of Nod, to the east of Eden (עדן קדמת).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 4:17 Instructor’s Translation

And he built a city and called the name of the city according to the name of his son Enoch.

Jonah in Jonah 4

Jonah 4:1 Instructor’s Translation

And [God's showing mercy to Nineveh] was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and there was heat-anger to him (ל ויחר-).

Jonah 4:4 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh said, "Is it doing good that there is heat-anger to you (חרה וזהיטב ולך)?"

Jonah 4:5 Instructor's Translation

And Jonah went out (ויצא) from the city and he sat from the east of the city (מקדם וישב) and made for himself a *sukkah* and he sat (וישב) under it.

The phrase "from before the face of Yahweh" also refers to the divine presence in the tabernacle ([Num. 17:7](#), [20:9](#); [1 Sam. 21:7](#)), divine judgment/fire ([Lev. 9:24](#), [10:2](#)), and incense ([Num. 16:40](#); [Lev. 16:12](#)). This instance in Jonah matches Cain's closely, especially in light of the Cain analogies at work in chapter 4.

Going to Tarshish

Tarshish has two main associations.

1. An exotic, distant nation: The name appears for the first time among the sons of Japeth ([Gen. 10:4](#)) among the distant island nations (with Elisha, Kittim, Dodanim).
2. A place of gold and precious gems: The name also refers to a precious stone that, according to Ezekiel, endowed the garden of Eden with its majestic splendor ([Ezek. 28:13](#)).

When these associations are combined, we can see Tarshish as a source of wealth and resources that people use to create their own versions of Eden, which then subjects them to judgment.

1 Kings 10:22 NASB

For the king [Solomon] had at sea the ships of Tarshish with the ships of Hiram; once every three years the ships of Tarshish came bringing gold and silver, ivory and apes and peacocks.

1 Kings 22:48 NASB

Jehoshaphat made ships of Tarshish to go to Ophir for gold, but they did not go for the ships were broken at Ezion-geber.

Just as in Jonah 1:4

The "ships of Tarshish" are a source of wealth, idolatry, and pagan influence in Israel and, therefore, a target for Yahweh's justice.

Isaiah 2:12, 16 Instructor's Translation

¹² For Yahweh of armies has a day ... ¹⁶ against all the ships of Tarshish, and against all the desirable ships.

Isaiah 23:1 Instructor's Translation

Wail, O ships of Tarshish,
for Tyre is destroyed without house or harbor;

Psalm 48:4-5, 7 Instructor's Translation

⁴ The kings assemble themselves together ...

⁵ They saw and were stunned ...

⁷ With the east wind

you break the ships of Tarshish.

Just as in Jonah 1:4

But Tarshish is eventually redeemed. The new Jerusalem will receive the gold from the ships of Tarshish ([Isa. 60:9](#), [72:10](#)). And in the messianic age, the witnesses will go out to the islands, including Tarshish ([Isa. 66:19](#)).

Tarshish plays the role of a pseudo-Eden, a place for precious stones that is exploited by human scheming (ships and trade routes). The destroyed ships of Tarshish become an image of God defeating humanity's search for Eden life on their own terms.

Jonah flees to Tarshish just as all biblical characters attempt some kind of "return to Eden" by their own power and scheming.

Reflection Question

In the biblical story, what kind of a place is Tarshish? What does it mean that Jonah flees there? Do you think this is a point that would be helpful for those in your context?